

reported growing inclusivity in the runners' community. The number of female finishers increased significantly in 2024, bettering the pre-COVID record of 690 in 2020 by 16.67 per cent. In 2025, the number stood at 962, which meant a further 19.5 per cent improvement over the previous year.

"I think there's power in normalising women pushing physical boundaries, especially in an industry where we're often boxed in," says Saiyami Kher, Bollywood actress, marathoner, Iron(wo)man, and cricket pundit.

She, in fact, is the only known Hindi cinema female actor to have taken part in not one but two 70.3s and two marathons! Kher explains how she managed to squeeze in rigorous training routines into a cramped schedule: "It's really tough (to balance work and training). I won't sugar-coat that. My shoots can go on for 12-14 hours, and finding time to train after that feels impossible sometimes. But you find a rhythm. You learn to prioritise, wake up early, train during breaks, use hotel gyms, cycle indoors... It also teaches you discipline and time management in the best way possible. And when you really want to do something, you make time." While Kher hopes to run a full Ironman soon, there are some who have been there and done that.

Raghul Sankaranarayanan, India's fastest Ironman, became the first from the country to qualify through rankings for the World Championships in 2022.

Also a certified triathlon coach and bike-fitter, Raghul has participated in 11 full Ironmans.

While he is happy to see so many people take a step towards a healthier lifestyle, he believes certain aspects of the triathlon may deter future sign-ups.

"Triathlon is very expensive, mainly because of cycling. The expense keeps multiplying; it never stops. The cycle alone ranges anywhere from INR 1-10 lakh, some priced even higher. Then you would have



SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

to keep upgrading the accessories if you want to remain in contention. Running is also not cheap these days. Training shoes, around INR 10,000-12,000, last 600-1000 kilometres. The racing shoes, equipped with carbon plates, come at INR 17,000-30,000. But these wear away easily." Besides expenditure, accessibility is also a concern. "The number of swimming pools and, in turn, quality swimmers is very less in India. Then, there is a dearth of quality cycling roads. It often gets dangerous," Raghul says.

Malvika Iyer (pic, above), a 30-year-old half-Ironman runner from Ghatkopar, Mumbai, admits endurance racing can be expensive, but says being smart and efficient helps keep costs down.

She says, "The cost of registration, travel, and specialised equipment, can make it feel a bit inaccessible to the average athlete. It depends on how smart you are in planning everything; need to sacrifice a few things here and there. You don't have to really spend a lot on travelling and high-end gear. I didn't. It's really nice to see this sport is

becoming more accessible for people like me - amateur athletes. The financial barriers still exist. We need to acknowledge that. However, I will still say your mindset is your biggest asset. With consistency, discipline, and some creative thinking, it is possible to take that first step without emptying your pockets."

Infrastructural hindrances are also why India hasn't been able to host a full-blooded Ironman yet. Neil says, "In Goa, we use the road leading to the airport to host the 70.3. The National Highway 66 shuts down for the race, and the traffic is rerouted through the service road on race day. If we organise a full-distance race, by afternoon, the road will get choked. So, that's not really an option."

However, he assured that Yoska is currently in talks with multiple parties to have a full-distance Ironman in another Indian city soon. Not just that, there are plans to host an Olympic triathlon (1.5-km swim, 40-km bike ride, and 10-km run) too under the Ironman banner.

The once-niche disciplines of hybrid racing and long-distance triathlons are gradually becoming the holy grail for those seeking transformation beyond aesthetics, and India is rising to the challenge one burpee and one kilometre at a time.



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